AI Video Bootcamp

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Color Grading Reference

Mood → Color → Prompt — The Complete Cheat Sheet

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Why Color Grading Matters For AI Video

Color is the first thing your brain processes, before story, before dialogue

Color grading is the single fastest way to make AI video look professional. A perfectly generated clip with flat color looks amateur. That same clip with the right color grade looks like it belongs in a movie.

The great news: you can bake color grading into your AI prompts. Instead of fixing it in post, you tell the AI exactly what color mood you want upfront.

This guide maps every common mood to its color palette, and gives you the exact words to use in your prompts.

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Mood-to-Color Map

Find your mood, steal the palette

Epic / Heroic

Palette: Rich golds, deep blues, warm highlights with cool shadows
Prompt words: "warm golden highlights, deep blue shadows, rich cinematic color grading, epic tone"

Dark / Moody

Palette: Desaturated, heavy shadows, teal and orange undertones
Prompt words: "dark moody color grading, desaturated tones, deep shadows, teal and orange palette"

Romantic / Dreamy

Palette: Soft pinks, warm golden tones, slight haze
Prompt words: "soft dreamy color grading, warm pink and gold tones, gentle haze, romantic atmosphere"

Horror / Unsettling

Palette: Cold greens, sickly yellows, high contrast, crushed blacks
Prompt words: "cold green-tinted color grading, sickly yellow undertones, high contrast, crushed blacks, unsettling"

Sci-Fi / Cyberpunk

Palette: Neon blues, magentas, teals against dark backgrounds
Prompt words: "neon-lit cyberpunk color grading, electric blue and magenta, dark backgrounds, high contrast"

Vintage / Nostalgic

Palette: Faded colors, warm yellows, slightly lifted blacks, grain
Prompt words: "vintage film color grading, faded warm tones, lifted blacks, nostalgic 35mm film grain"

Clean / Corporate

Palette: Bright, slightly cool, high key, minimal shadows
Prompt words: "clean bright color grading, slightly cool tone, high key lighting, professional"

Nature / Documentary

Palette: Rich greens, warm earth tones, natural saturation
Prompt words: "natural documentary color grading, rich greens, warm earth tones, organic feel"

Melancholy / Lonely

Palette: Desaturated blues and greys, cold tones, overcast feel
Prompt words: "desaturated blue-grey color grading, cold melancholic tone, muted colors, overcast"

High Energy / Action

Palette: High contrast, punchy saturation, warm tones with cool accents
Prompt words: "high contrast punchy color grading, vibrant saturation, action film tone"

Luxury / Elegant

Palette: Deep blacks, gold accents, warm highlights, rich contrast
Prompt words: "luxurious color grading, deep rich blacks, golden accents, elegant warm highlights"

Surreal / Dreamlike

Palette: Unnatural color shifts, pastels mixed with deep tones, soft focus
Prompt words: "surreal dreamlike color grading, shifted color palette, pastel and deep tones mixed"

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Film Look References

Reference real films to get specific looks

Sometimes the fastest way to describe a color grade is to reference a film. Here are looks you can reference directly in your prompts:

Blade Runner 2049 look

Heavy orange and teal, smoky atmosphere, neon accents in darkness

Mad Max: Fury Road look

Crushed teal shadows with blazing orange/amber highlights, extreme contrast

The Matrix look

Green tint throughout, dark shadows, desaturated except for green

Wes Anderson look

Pastel color blocking, symmetrical, warm vintage tones

Ozark / Gone Girl look

Cold steel blue, desaturated, flat, oppressive

La La Land look

Rich saturated primaries, golden hour warmth, vibrant but elegant

John Wick look

Deep neon blue and red contrast against pitch black, high contrast

Dune look

Warm amber and sand tones, hazy atmosphere, desaturated blues

Barbie look

Hot pink saturation, bright highlights, candy-colored, high key

The Revenant look

Cold natural light, blue-grey shadows, raw and earthy

Color Grading Prompt Formula

When writing your AI prompt, put color grading at the END, after your scene description. The AI weights the end of prompts heavily.

Formula: [Scene description] + [lighting source] + [color grade style] + [film reference if needed]

Example prompts:

"A lone astronaut standing on Mars, looking at the horizon, volumetric light from the setting sun, warm amber and teal cinematic color grading, Dune-inspired look"

"A woman sitting in a neon-lit diner at 3am, rain on the windows, moody blue and magenta color grading, Wong Kar-wai inspired, soft focus"

"A medieval king sitting on a throne in a dark hall, candlelight, warm golden highlights with deep black shadows, Game of Thrones color grading, cinematic"

Common Mistakes:

- Don't say "colorful" — it means nothing specific. Say exactly which colors and where
- Don't stack too many color references — pick one mood, one palette
- Don't forget lighting — color grading and lighting are connected, you can't have warm golden grading with harsh fluorescent lighting
- Don't over-describe — "teal and orange cinematic color grading" is better than a paragraph about specific RGB values

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